

PIZZA AL FRESCO An open air, brick and woodfire pizza oven at the Lodge dishes out moreish varieties

century temples, intricately carved plinths and pillars reaching up to the open sky. Amidst placid rurality, the place bursts with energy. Warrior men and women battle *vyala*, magical beasts with leonine heads and horse-bodies. Kirtimukha gargoyles keep evil at bay. Door lintels that now lead nowhere are crowded with apsaras singing and dancing around deities. And each deity contains multitudes: Surya, Vishnu, Shiva, Brahma with their distinct iconography combined in a single figure. There is a Devi temple. All are abandoned except the almost intact Neelkanth Mahadev with its shikhara of weathered sandstone, and a stepwell beside it. Peafowl pick their way through wildflowers and grasses growing among the ruins. An eight-metre-high statue of the Jain Tirthankar Shantinath keeps solitary watch over this fallen splendour.

It is all quite marvellous. My mind is full of conjecture, but the Archaeological Survey of India which protects the temples has forgotten to provide any information for visitors. I learn later from an art historian friend that these temples were built more than a thousand years ago when this region was a part of Paranagar, a Pratihara dynasty principality. Within a hundred or so years, the community that worshipped and maintained them had vanished. We may never know why. As we sip tea and munch biscuits on worn steps overlooking an old pond, I'm struck by how much more there is to wonder at if one looks beyond tigers at the natural and cultural landscape they inhabit. If it wasn't for the closed Tiger Reserve, I may never have discovered this tucked-away jewel.

Brunch, back at the Lodge, consists of fruit, home-baked bread, fluffy omelettes, and good coffee. The menu is eclectic. The gazpacho and Caprese salad sparkle with the flavour of freshly picked tomatoes. At dinner, the Rajasthani dishes include garlic-sautéed *chaulai*, a seasonal green. The service is solicitous, sometimes to excess, but the young staff will soon learn that not every guest wants to be escorted everywhere. Or that not everyone wants that a towel used to dry hands once should be instantly replaced. They mean well, but it goes against the eco-friendly ethos the Lodge seeks to build.

After a blissful massage, part of the Tibetan healing therapies that the spa offers, I doze on the large swing by my pool, imagining how delighted my four-year-old nieces would be to paddle here, chasing dragonflies and giant toads. Or sitting astride a horse, gently clip-clopping around the paddock. There is tonnes to do at the Sariska Lodge. Even if the only large cat you see is embroidered on your window blind. ■